

CHIPPING AWAY

The wily Maratha strongman is up to his old tricks again as he looks to undercut the Congress by striking deals with its rivals to capture power at the state and local levels

■ By Mallni Bhupta

Sharad Pawar is on the prowl yet again. With assembly elections in Maharashtra and general elections less than a year away, the master strategist and chief architect of rebellions is back to his old tactics—which his detractors are, by now, all too familiar with—of trying to wrest power at any cost. Considering that his ambitions are no longer restricted to his home state, he has not only started consolidating allies for an alternative front at the Centre, but has also started systematically decimating the Congress wherever possible, from the North-east to New Delhi. With his eyes firmly set on taking hold of the Prime Minister's Office, the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) supremo is pulling out every trick from his version of the Arthashastra to contain his *bete noire*, the Congress party.

In the North-east, the foxy Maratha leader is especially focusing on upsetting the Congress's moves in Meghalaya. Despite being an alliance partner with the Congress at the Centre and in Maharashtra, NCP has stitched up a coalition with the United Democratic Party to form the Meghalaya Progressive Alliance in a bid to capture power in the state. But his attempt to beat the Congress has come to naught as the Meghalaya governor has asked the Congress—the single-largest party with 25 seats in the 60-member House—to form the Government and prove their majority. What happens in Meghalaya between the Congress and NCP will set the tone of their alliances in the coming year as relations between the two parties are now well beyond repair.

The battleground may have shifted to Meghalaya in 2008, but Pawar's anti-Congress strategy was first rolled out in Maharashtra last year. He cozied up to Shiv Sena chief Bal Thackeray to

split the Congress vote in several by-elections in the state and Congress insiders in Maharashtra feel his moves are now well outside the realm of political correctness. Having found support from select quarters, Pawar's plan involves forging new relationships with different parties on one hand and on the other, systematically weakening the Congress in its traditional strongholds. Maharashtra Pradesh Congress Committee chief Prabha Rau has been cautioning the party headquarters about Pawar's guerrilla tactics for a while. Says Rau, "All this is a matter of grave concern to us." The fact that the Congress is not a cadre-based party and is disconnected from grassroots politics has only helped Pawar. The NCP chief is known as a rebel without a cause in political circles, an apt description given that he has drifted from the comforts of the



SPREADING WINGS: NCP's P.A. Sangma (second from left, front row) with other members of MPA Congress fold thrice. Leading rebellions is his forte, whether it is to split and form a new party or encourage a revolt within rival parties.

What started as an experiment in

Pune corporation—where NCP partnered with the Shiv Sena—has now become par for the course for this modern-day Machiavelli and his party across India. In order to contain the Congress in the state well before the next assembly elections, NCP has partnered with the Shiv Sena in the